The integration of systemically important states into the liberal international order also fits with theories grounded in hegemonic stability and the Bretton Woods regime as essential providers of public goods.[43] American leadership has helped produce the triumph of market-based democracies, progressive openness to trade, and dramatic increases in living standards since World War II. The United States as a liberal hegemon promotes cooperation by providing the market of last resort; offering stable long-term lending, including lending in crises; ensuring a deep, liquid, and open capital market that buttresses the world's dominant reserve currency as a safe haven; and helping to coordinate macroeconomic policies.[44] The hegemon accomplishes such goals by mitigating distributional conflict and enforcement problems while accepting formal rules that reduce incentives to exploit weaker partners.[45]

One can find some evidence of a preference for such a global system among the BRICS, as demonstrated by China's "peaceful rise" strategy[46] and the BRICS' collective financial statecraft decision to contribute billions of dollars to the IMF during the recent global financial crisis. The IMF would better safeguard their capital than bilateral loans, but as important for these rising powers was the signal that they are "responsible stakeholders,"[47] worthy of greater voting power and leadership positions. According to Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, China seeks "to play a bigger role in the existing international order and system" but is "not building a rival system."[48]

The historical record shows that the United States actively facilitated conditions for the emerging powers to behave as *joiners*, but only in economic multilateral institutions and international markets, not in U.S. alliances, and not in ways that displaced American preponderance.[49] China was an early beneficiary of the American strategy at the time of the establishment of the Bretton Woods institutions, winning the fourth-largest quota and number of voting shares in the IMF and World Bank, above France, Brazil, and India, all of which had lobbied to be among the major players. As discussed in Chapter 4, from the 1940s, in preparation for the Bretton Woods Conference, through the Cold War, and especially after the normalization of relations in the 1970s under President Richard Nixon and Chairman Mao Zedong, China urgently appealed for permission to participate in the IMF and World Bank, gain a high quota level, and sit at